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Giving kids an edible treat that you know they love after a tricky day to cheer them up or soothe them can be tempting but I advise you not to.

When we try to comfort a child with food rather than attend to their physical and emotional needs, we leave them feeling not understood.

Instead of learning that they'll receive appropriate comfort and attention, they receive the message that their needs can't or won't be met appropriately.

Consequently, they understand one of the following: that their needs are not valid; that they are too much for their parent; that they are being silly; that next time they should keep quiet; or that they need to shout louder to be heard.

If, after tending to your child's emotional and physical wounds you want to offer some chocolate, ice cream or a trip to a fast-food restaurant, that is, of course completely fine — but it must not replace the nurture.